STORIES FROM THE QURAN · 7

Maryam and the Date Palm

مريم والنخلة



Long ago, a woman from the family of ‘Imran was expecting a baby. She prayed: “My Lord, I give the child I am carrying to You, to serve You. Please accept it from me.”

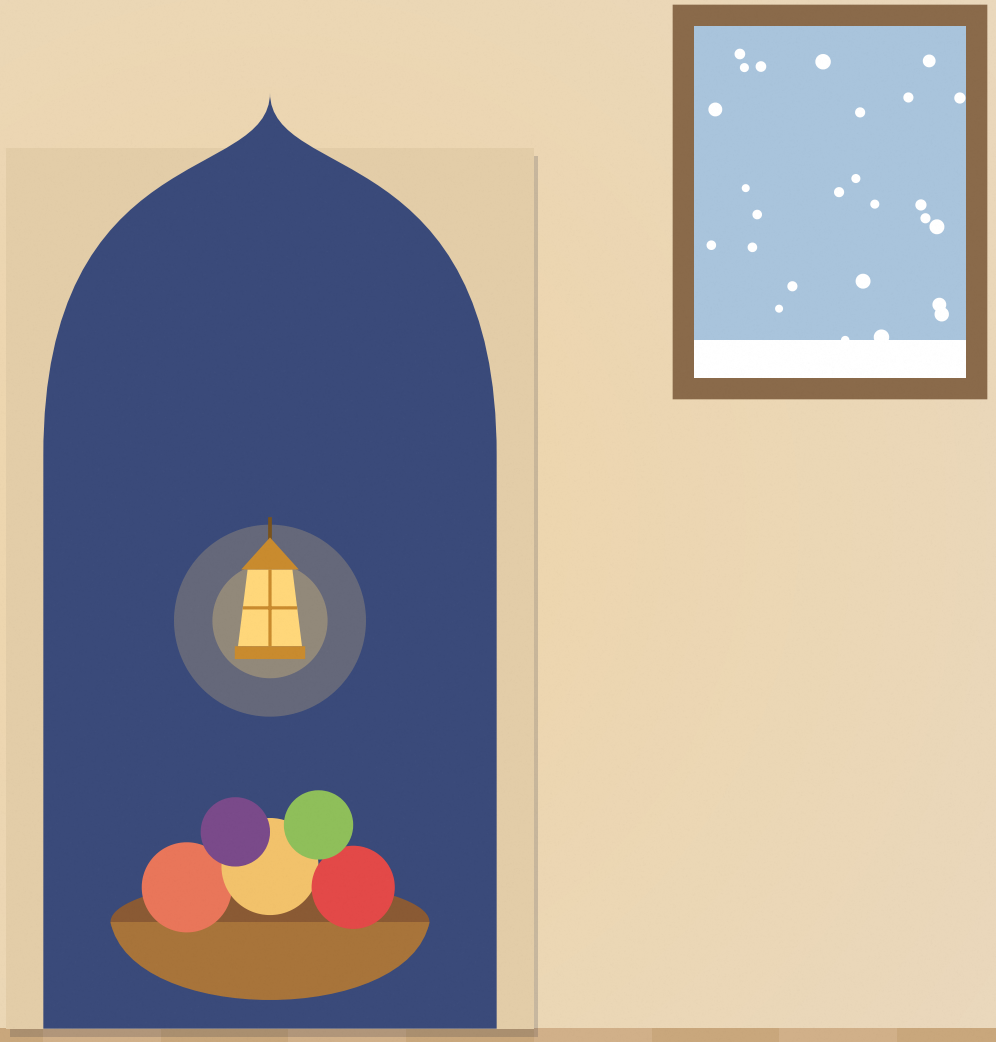


Her baby was a girl. “I have named her Maryam,” said her mother, “and I ask You to protect her and her children.”

And Allah accepted Maryam with a beautiful acceptance.

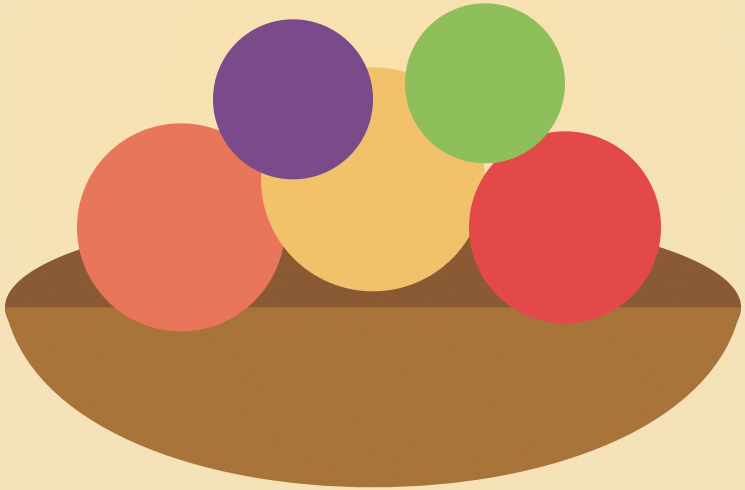


Prophet Zakariyya looked after Maryam. She spent her days in a quiet prayer room, worshipping Allah. Every time Zakariyya came in, he found fresh food beside her.



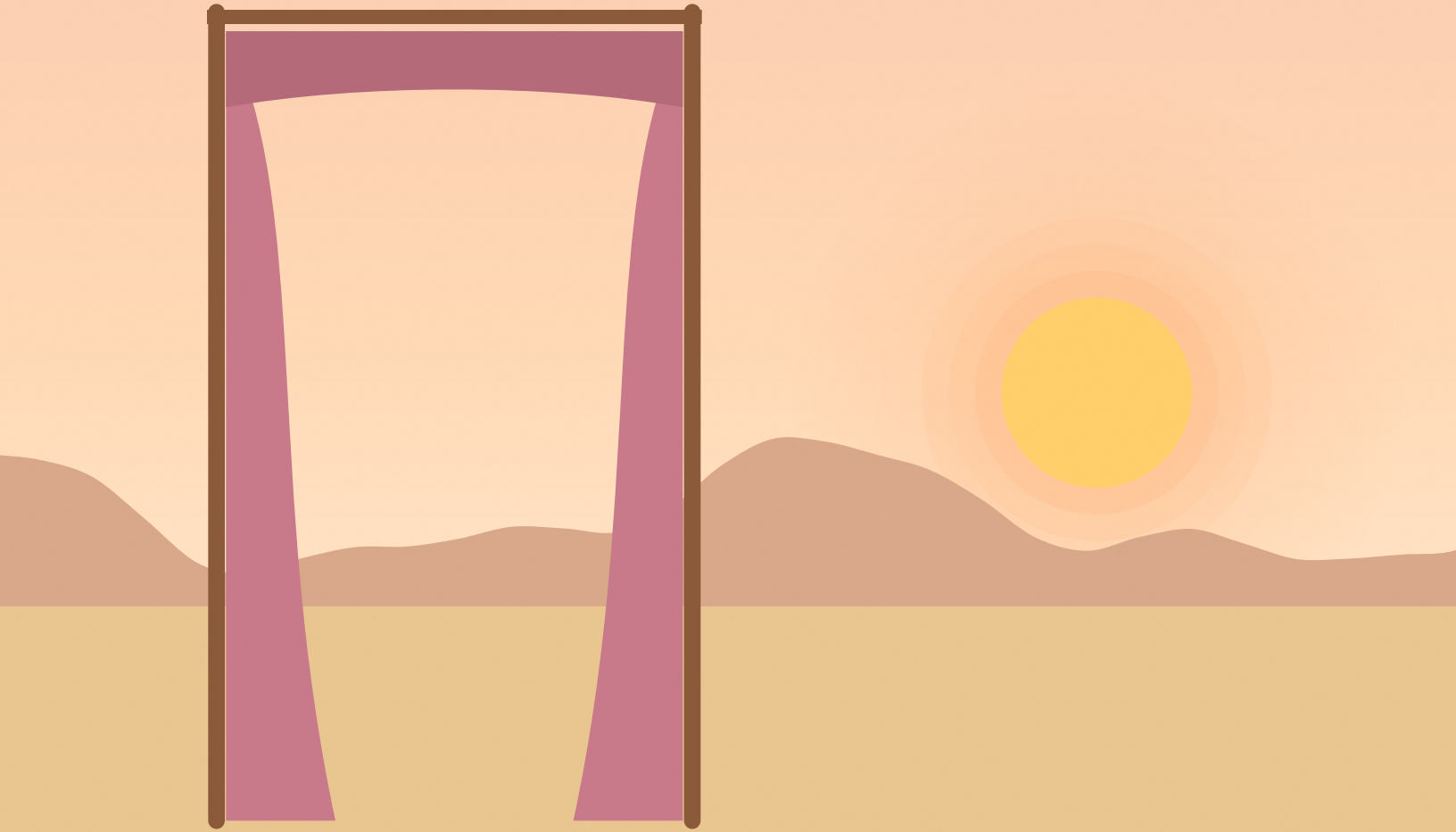
“Maryam,” he asked, “where does this come from?”

“It is from Allah,” she said. “Allah gives to whoever He wills, more than can be counted.”



Maryam grew up good and pure, and Allah chose her above all the women of the world.

One day she went to a quiet place to the east, and hung a curtain to be alone.



Allah sent an angel to her. “I am a messenger from your Lord,” he said, “to give you a pure baby boy.”

“How can I have a son?” asked Maryam. “No man has married me.”

“It is easy for Allah,” said the angel. “He only says ‘Be!’, and it is. Your son will be a sign for people, and a mercy from Allah.”

When the time came near, Maryam went away to a place far from everyone.



She came to the trunk of a date palm. She was tired and in pain, and very worried about what people would say.



Then a voice called to her from below: “Do not be sad! Your Lord has made a little stream flow beneath you.”



“Shake the trunk of the palm tree towards you, and fresh, ripe dates will fall down for you.”



“So eat, and drink, and be happy.”

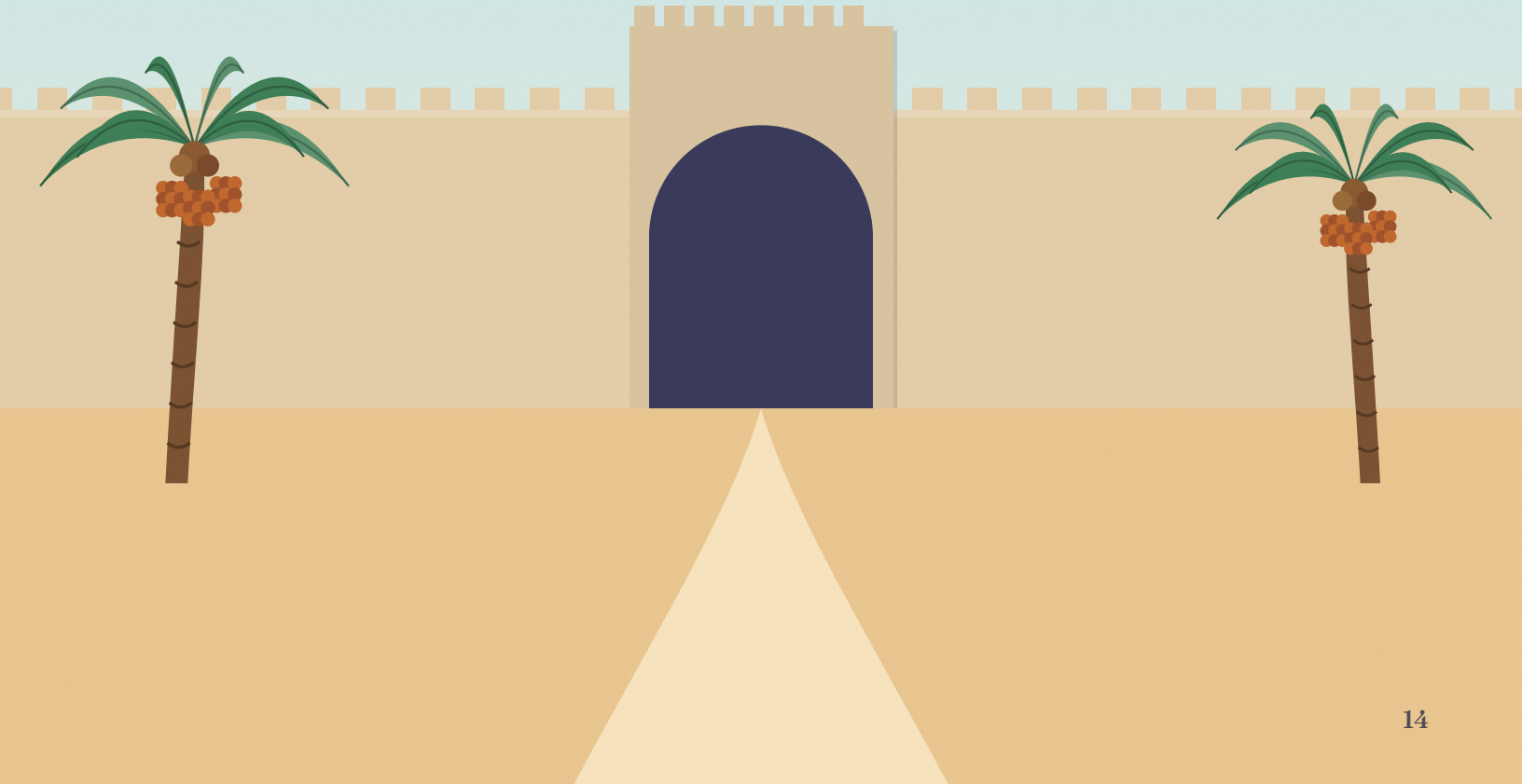
And Maryam’s baby was born: a boy named ‘Isa (peace be upon him).







Maryam came back to her people, carrying her baby. Allah had told her: “If you see anyone, do not speak today.”



“Maryam!” the people cried. “You have done something strange!”

Maryam did not answer. She simply pointed to the baby.

“How can we talk to a baby in a cradle?” they said.



Then baby ʻIsa spoke!

“I am the servant of Allah. He has given me the Book, and made me a prophet. He has made me kind to my mother.”



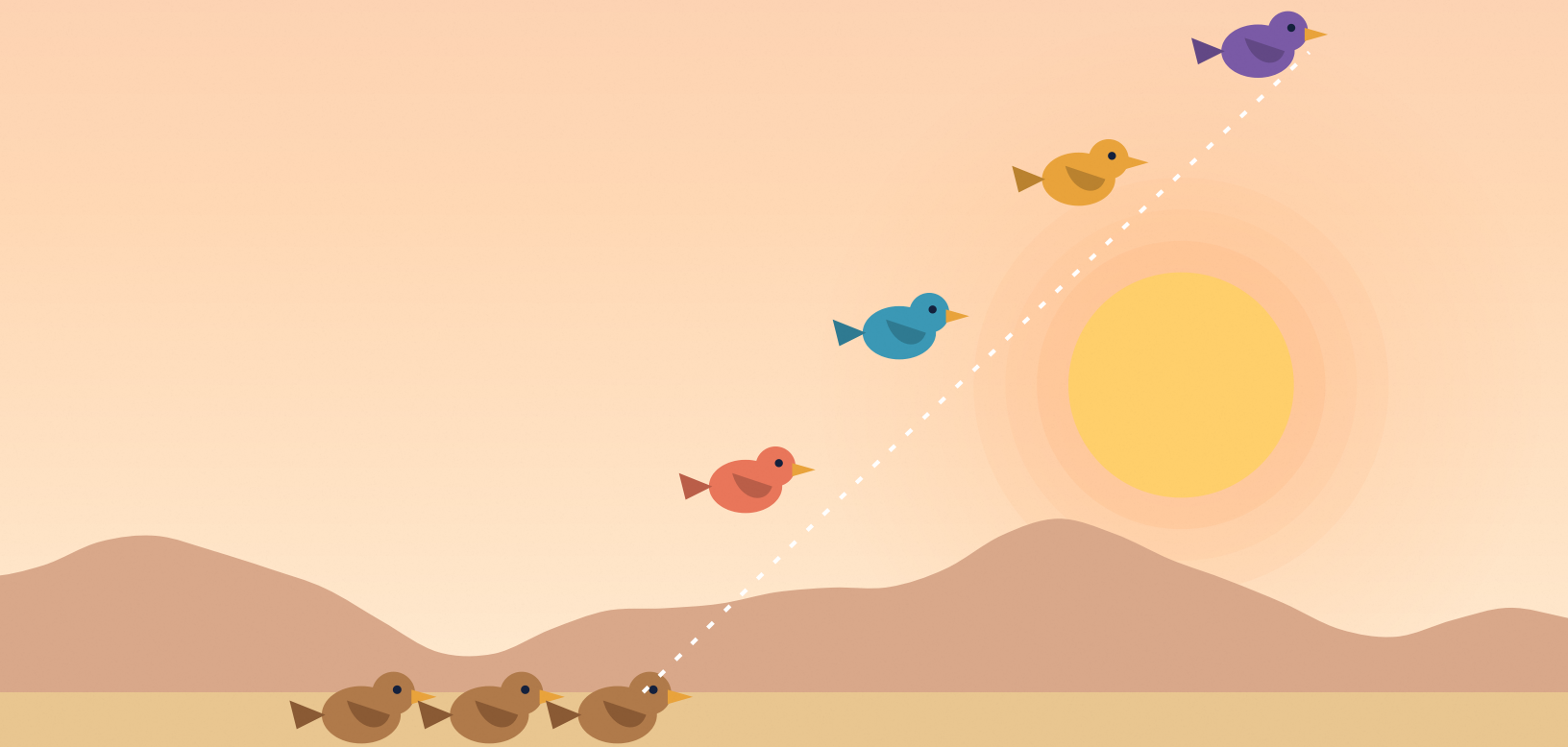
“Peace be on me the day I was born, the day I die, and the day I am raised to life again.”

Everyone had heard a newborn baby speak.



‘Isa grew up to be a great prophet. By Allah’s permission, he shaped birds from clay, breathed into them, and they flew away as real birds!

And his mother Maryam is remembered by name in the Quran forever.



Say Maryam's words

Maryam said this when Zakariyya asked where her food came from. You can say it about every good thing you have.

هُوَ مِنْ عِندِ ٱللَّهِ

Huwa min ʻindillāh

It is from Allah.

إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ يَرْزُقُ مَن يَشَآءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسَابٍ

Innallāha yarzuqu man yashāʼu bighayri ḥisāb

Allah gives to whoever He wills, more than can be counted.

From Surah Al ʻImran, 3:37

What does the story teach us?

Everything good is from Allah.
“It is from Allah,” said Maryam.

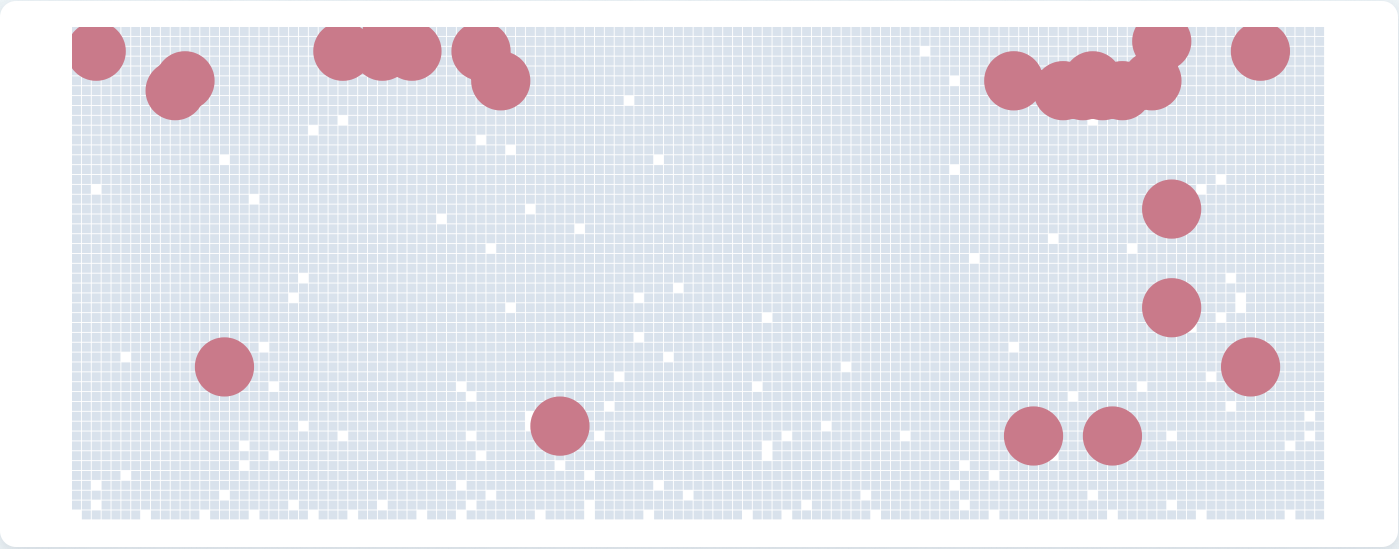
Nothing is too hard for Allah.
“It is easy for Allah. He says ‘Be!’, and it is.”

When you are sad, Allah sends help.
A stream and fresh dates, right when Maryam needed them.

Be kind to your mother.
Baby ‘Isa said Allah made him kind to his mother.

Did you know?

Maryam is the only woman called by her name in the Quran, and **Surah Maryam**, number 19, is named after her. Her son ʻIsa is named **25** times.



Every verse of the Quran is one tiny square, starting at the top right like a page of the Quran. Each dot is a verse that names ʻIsa.

The Quran compares ʻIsa to Adam: Allah made both by saying “Be!” (3:59). Counted by name, Adam is also named exactly 25 times.

Look closer

Some pictures hide a secret from the Quran itself. Go back and find them.

p. 4 Snow at the window, and summer fruit in the bowl. The commentators said Zakariyya found fruit out of season (3:37).

p. 11 The little stream. The Quran's word is *sariyy* (19:24).

p. 12 Fresh, ripe dates. The word for them, *ruṭab*, is used only once in the whole Quran (19:25).

p. 17 Three stars: the day he was born, the day he dies, and the day he is raised (19:33).

p. 18 Birds of clay. In 5:110, Allah says "by My permission" four times in a single verse, for each of 'Isa's miracles.

For parents

Where the story is told. Al ʻImran 3:35–37 and 3:42–49, Maryam 19:16–34, and Al-Maʼidah 5:110.

Told in simple words. This is a retelling for young children, not a translation. The angel (19:17, “Our spirit”, understood as Jibril) is shown only as light. How ʻIsa came to be is told as the verses tell it: “It is easy for Allah.” The fruit out of season comes from the commentaries. The place of the birth is not named in the Quran.

The pictures. By custom, no prophet is drawn, and in this series no person at all. The pictures show the places, the light and the creatures, so your child can picture the story around them.

Talk about it. Maryam was worried about what people would say. What do you do when you are worried?

Illustrators welcome. These first pictures are a starting point. Artists are invited to redraw any book; the Books page of the Quran Atlas has a brief for every page.

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